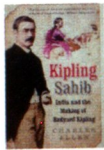


KIPLING UNBOUND

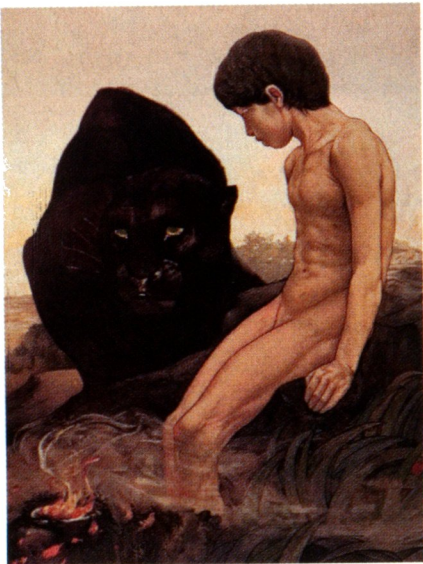
This outstanding biography makes sense of the troubled writer who has been caricatured as an imperialist



KIPLING SAHIB: INDIA AND THE MAKING OF RUDYARD KIPLING
by CHARLES ALLEN
Little, Brown
Price: Rs 795, Pages: 426

■ By Gillian Wright

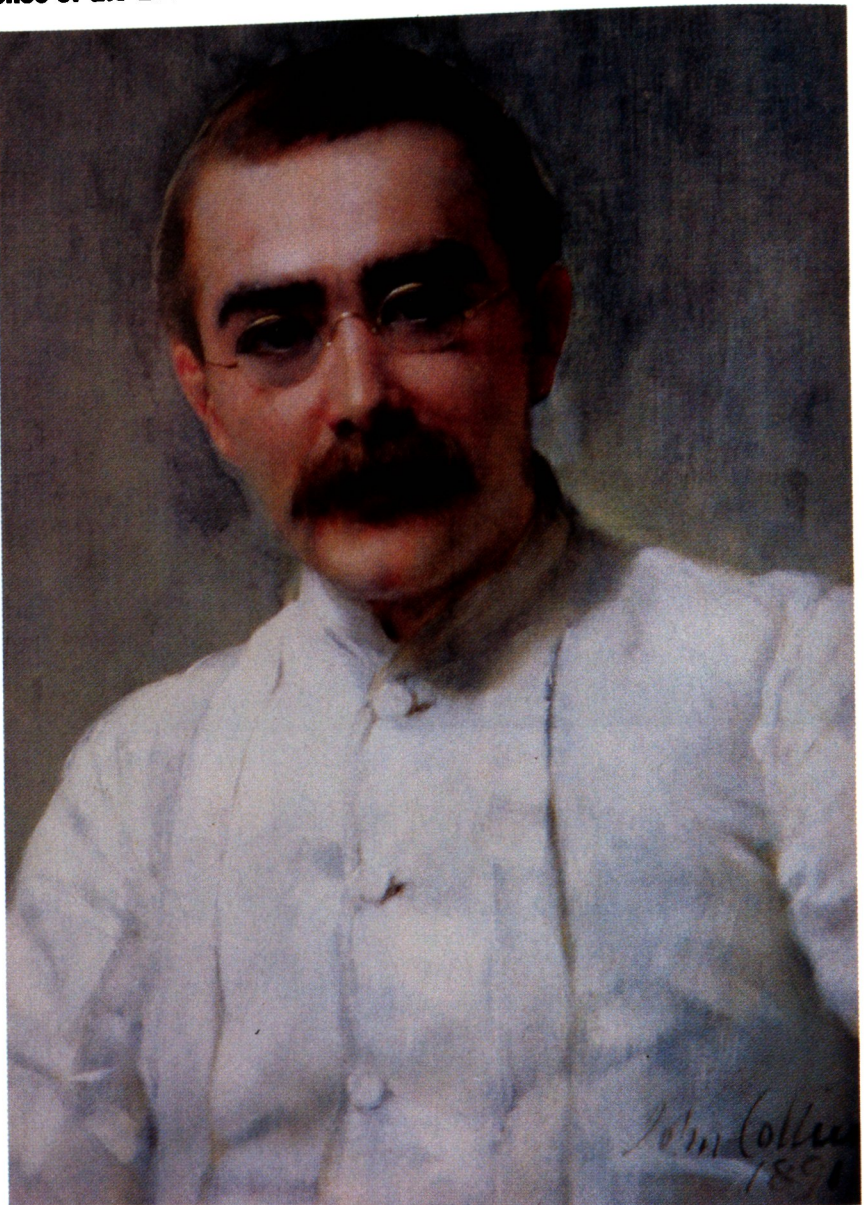
In 1890s Britain, no one doubted the genius of Rudyard Kipling. The author Jerome K. Jerome wrote, "He appears to have dominated the universe to the exclusion of all other beliefs." And Charles Allen, the author of this outstanding biography, sums it up thus, "What made Kipling so hugely popular was his seemingly unerring instinct for saying not exactly what the public wanted to hear but what most needed to be said, and for saying



it directly and in a way that was instantly quotable."

Since then Kipling has been reviled as an imperialist and his poetry dismissed as doggerel. Yet millions of Indian schoolchildren still recite "If" and know who Mowgli was. Kipling is defined by his Indian writing and his characterisation of Indians in his novel *Kim* is truer than E.M. Forster's.

Charles Allen's great-grandfather George Allen was the proprietor of the newspaper which gave Kipling his break as a journalist. Having grown up



WEST SIDE STORY: Kipling at 25; (left) Mowgli, Bagheera from *The Jungle Book*

surrounded by Kipling memorabilia, Allen claims he was born to write *Kipling Sahib: India and the Making of Rudyard Kipling*. Ruddy, as Kipling was known to family and friends, would not have agreed. He abhorred any public mention of his private life and burned his personal papers so that, in his own words, "no one can make a monkey out of me when I'm dead".

Allen has not made a monkey of him; he has made sense of him. Ruddy

was a brilliant, troubled and sometimes cruel man. He was part of a close-knit, artistic family made up of his parents, himself and his sister Trixie. They believed in the inferiority of Indians but were themselves considered inferiors by the highest echelons of British society.

As a child in Bombay, Ruddy spent most of his time with doting servants and became like his hero Kim, "the little friend of all the world". Both children were then banished to England for a Dickensian education